

World in Brief: Venezuela earthquakes death toll tops 1,400; America and Iran trade blows



Photograph: AFP via Getty Images

Rescue efforts continued in **Venezuela** as the death toll from Wednesday's [earthquakes](#) rose to over 1,400. Tens of thousands of people are still believed to be missing. Around 3,300 are injured. Initial projections from the United Nations Development Programme suggest that the economic impact of the disaster may amount to roughly 6% of GDP. The two quakes are the country's largest—and possibly deadliest—in over a century.

America and **Iran** continued to trade blows, despite [their ceasefire](#). Iran shot missiles and drones at Bahrain and Kuwait, which both host American bases, after America launched more strikes against Iranian facilities on Saturday. The renewed fighting started when Iran attacked a Singapore-flagged cargo ship on Thursday. Donald Trump said that if Iran does not stop violating the truce America may be “forced to militarily complete the job”.

Ukraine reported new drone attacks targeting a major oil refinery in **Russia's** Krasnodar region, which serves Russian-occupied Crimea. Ukraine claimed it struck a second refinery in the Yaroslavl region, approximately 700km from its border. Volodymyr Zelensky, Ukraine's president, said the attacks were a response to

“Russian terror”. This week Mr Zelensky ordered 40 days of [intense strikes](#) on Russia to press Vladimir Putin to end the war.

Europe’s heatwave caused around 1,000 excess deaths in **France** this week, the country’s public health agency said. It noted that individuals aged 65 and over accounted for 85% of the fatalities documented since Wednesday. More than 191m people across the continent still faced temperatures of over 35°C (95°F) on Sunday, with extreme heat warnings issued in Czechia, [Germany](#), Hungary and Poland.

Manuel Adorni, the chief of staff to Javier Milei, Argentina’s president, resigned. Mr Adorni is under investigation for graft, including lavish trips and the purchase of a flat at a suspiciously low price. He denies wrongdoing. Mr Milei has consistently backed his man. The scandal, which broke in March, has sapped the president’s popularity, as has [the economy’s poor performance](#).

Muhoozi Kainerugaba, **Uganda’s** army chief and the son of the president, shut down an independent TV station and newspaper. “I DO NOT believe in a free press”, General Kainerugaba wrote on social media, though he did not give a reason for the closure. In January he [threatened to kill](#) an opposition leader after his father, who has ruled since 1986, won a disputed election.

Harry Kane scored in England’s 2-0 group-stage victory against Panama. That brings his tally of **World Cup** goals to 11, unseating Gary Lineker as England’s most prolific goalscorer in the tournament. Despite a somewhat uninspiring performance, the Three Lions’ will proceed to the knock-out stages. Lionel Messi, who holds the record for most goals scored at the World Cup, took his count to 19 after scoring against Jordan.

Word of the week: “soul doc”. The nickname for Claude’s 78-page constitution of rules and principles at Anthropic. Read about the [work of philosophers](#) at the AI lab.

*How well do you know the week's news? Test your knowledge with
our [quiz](#).*

How safe and sound are stablecoins?

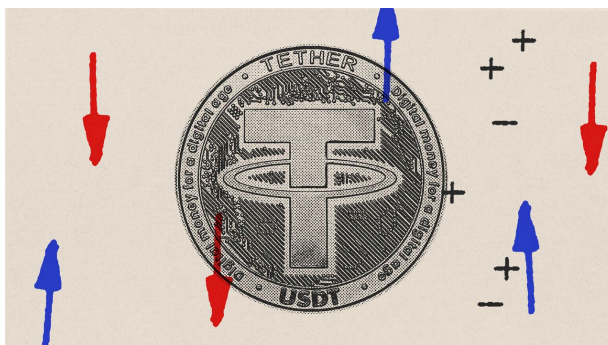


Illustration: The Economist

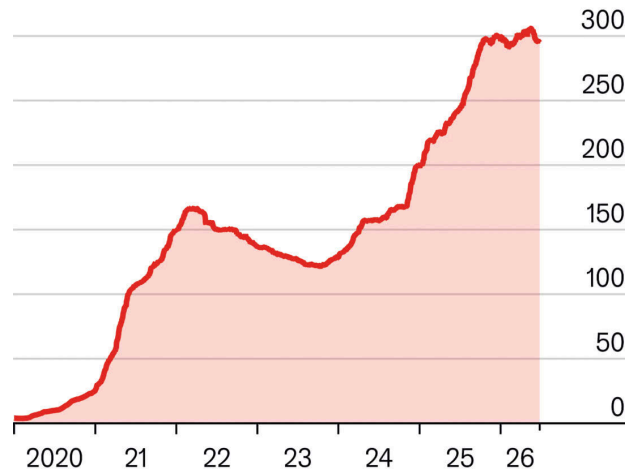
The Bank for International Settlements, the global forum for central banks, is once again sounding the alarm on stablecoins, cryptocurrencies pegged to fiat ones. In its annual economic report, released on Sunday, it argues that the growth of the crypto tokens could sap demand for bank deposits or that they could prove shaky in moments of market stress.

But the argument may now be losing relevance. The amount of stablecoins circulating boomed last year as the Trump administration carved a regulatory path for issuing them in America. [It has since slowed](#): there are around \$314bn in stablecoins right now, barely more than there were eight months ago.

Growth has stalled because riskier crypto assets have slumped. The price of bitcoin has dropped from over \$120,000 in October to \$60,000. If the stock of stablecoins remains closely linked to the health of the crypto industry generally, sceptics may have less to worry about.

Collateral damage

Stablecoins, total market capitalisation, \$bn



Source: RWA.xyz

A growing arsenal against Ebola



Photograph: Alamy

Congo's Ebola outbreak continues to spread. More than 1,000 cases and 270 deaths have been confirmed, though the true number is higher. The World Health Organisation, among others, has set up treatment and testing centres and flown in [protective equipment and other supplies](#). But officials fear the outbreak may spill into neighbouring South Sudan, where long-running armed conflict would make containing an outbreak far more difficult.

This week [Congo](#) will begin trials of two new drugs, called MBP134 and remdesivir. Researchers hope that the two treatments, alone or in combination, might reduce mortality in Ebola patients. Results could be available in a few weeks. There are also plans to test three vaccines against the Bundibugyo strain of Ebola causing this outbreak, which is different from the strain for which an approved vaccine exists. But the vaccines are still undergoing tests for efficacy in animals and safety in humans before they can be shipped to Congo for trials on the ground.

Staying proud in America



Photograph: AP

On Sunday several American cities including New York, Chicago and San Francisco hold Pride parades. Many started in 1970 to commemorate the 1969 [Stonewall uprising](#) after a police raid on a gay bar in New York. Support for gay rights increased only gradually, but gay marriage was finally legalised nationwide in 2015. More recently support [is sliding](#): 62% of Americans surveyed this year by Gallup believe same-sex relations are “morally acceptable”, down from 71% in 2022. The drop is most pronounced among Republicans, falling from 56% to 35%.

Still, some 2.5m people are expected to turn out at the largest parade, in New York, to march past the Stonewall National Monument—itsself a renewed site of tension. In February its [Pride flag](#) was removed after the National Parks Service, which runs the site, ordered that only the American flag or banners of the Interior Department could be flown in parks, “with limited exceptions”. The flag was recently restored after activists sued.

The many faces of Frida Kahlo



Photograph: Kevin Lake/Jack Arts/Tate Modern

When Frida Kahlo's painting "El Sueño" sold for \$54.7m at auction last year, it became the most expensive work ever by a female artist. The Mexican painter, who died in 1954, may now be among the most commercially valuable names in art. This week the Tate Modern in London opened "Frida: The Making of an Icon". The exhibition has already broken the gallery's record for advance ticket sales.

The show includes over 30 of Kahlo's artworks alongside personal artefacts, to show her connections to her contemporaries and her creative influence on later artists. Kahlo's combination of brightly coloured folk art, quasi-religious iconography and frank self-portraiture has made her paintings instantly recognisable, helping turn her into a merchandising phenomenon. Yet her appeal extends beyond her paintings. She is for many a symbol of resilience, feminism and self-expression, even as her life was marked by political extremism, heavy drinking and difficult personal relationships.

Weekend profile: Andy Burnham, Britain's prime minister-in-waiting



Photograph: Getty Images

A fun way of thinking about British prime ministers is to imagine what they would do if they were not running the country. Sir Keir Starmer, [who quit mid-term](#) on June 22nd, would probably be a lawyer, as he was before entering politics—although it is possible to imagine him as a hygiene inspector. Boris Johnson might be an airline boss or the owner of a football team. David Cameron, with his quick wit and smooth demeanour, would surely be a public-relations executive. But [Andy Burnham](#), who will almost certainly replace Sir Keir, would only ever be a politician.

That is not because Mr Burnham has always been a politician, although this is nearly true. He became an MP a quarter-century ago, rising into the cabinet during the final, doomed years of the New Labour era. He tried to become party leader in 2010, but failed. A second attempt in 2015 fared little better. In 2017 he took a newly invented job as mayor of Greater Manchester, which was the making of him.

The real reason why it is so hard to imagine Mr Burnham doing anything else is that he seems to enjoy politics so much. He likes meeting people; he likes talking; he likes persuading. His job rarely seems to get him down. People like meeting Mr Burnham, too. Americans sometimes talk about the “beer question”: which

politician would you rather have a pint with? By that measure, Mr Burnham would trounce almost anyone.

He does not relish making decisions, however—especially the kind that will leave one side angry. His last job was perfect for him, because the mayor of Greater Manchester has few formal powers. He spent a decade as a convenor, a negotiator and a cheerleader, rather than as a chief executive. Even so, he managed to make some poor choices, insisting that “green belt” land be preserved and stepping back from a clean-air scheme that would have angered motorists.

Mr Burnham’s political philosophy is similar to Sir Keir’s, not least in being vague. Both men sit somewhere near the middle of the Labour Party, putting them substantially to the left of the country. Both believe deeply in righting wrongs, especially those inflicted by the state. Mr Burnham has a crowd-pleasing streak, which could help him compete with the populist parties that menace Labour: the Greens and Reform UK. Like the current prime minister, he has yet to set out a convincing plan to fix Britain. But his leadership is going to look and feel very different.

Mini crossword

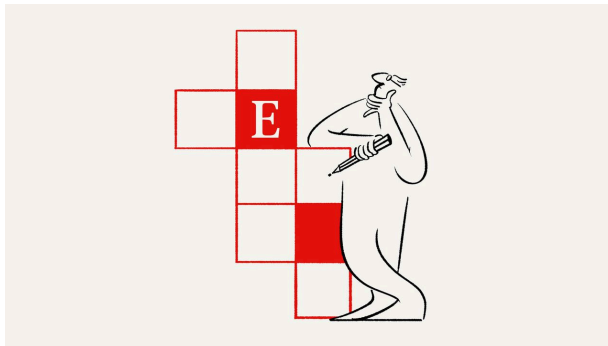


Illustration: The Economist

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it [here](#). Or, if you prefer, use the clues below.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Cryptic clues

1 across - City that's attractively formed has humble beginning (5)

2 across - Poor cat eats sea creature (4)

3 across - Give up profit (5)

1 down - Holy hippo's revolutionary ideology (10)

Straight clues

1 across - Found in Scotland and Western Australia (5)

2 across - Toothed whale (4)

3 across - Total amount of a crop (5)

1 down - Its branches include aesthetics and logic (10)

*One can never consent to creep
when one feels an impulse to soar.*

Helen Keller